Important Update

2026-09-14 00:00:00

On September 14, 2026, the U.S. District Court for the District of Massachusetts issued an order pausing the effective date of the Department of Homeland Security's Duration of Status Final Rule while litigation concerning the rule continues.

LEARN MORE

Reduced Course Load

Jump to a Section

What Is a Reduced Course Load?

International F-1 and J-1 students are required to enroll in and complete a full course load each semester to maintain valid nonimmigrant student status. A Reduced Course Load (RCL) is an authorized exception for F-1/J-1 international students to enroll in fewer credits than the standard full-time requirement while maintaining legal visa status.

There are only a few exceptions to the full-time enrollment requirement for the fall and spring semesters. Each exception has its own criteria, which are outlined below.

Back to Top

Exceptions to Full-Time Enroll

Need help?

Hi there! I'm Tommy, and I am here to answer your questions. What can I help with?

Important Update

2026-09-14 00:00:00

On September 14, 2026, the U.S. District Court for the District of Massachusetts issued an order pausing the effective date of the Department of Homeland Security's Duration of Status Final Rule while litigation concerning the rule continues.

LEARN MORE

USC

Office of International Services

Maintaining Status | Students

How to Apply for a Reduced Course Load

Reduced Course Load Deadline

Important Notes

Back to Top

Related Pages

Leave of Absence

Back to Top

Need help?



Hi there! I'm Tommy, and I am here to answer your questions. What can I help with?

Important Update

2026-09-14 00:00:00

On September 14, 2026, the U.S. District Court for the District of Massachusetts issued an order pausing the effective date of the Department of Homeland Security's Duration of Status Final Rule while litigation concerning the rule continues.

LEARN MORE

USC

Office of International Services

Maintaining Status | Students

Quick Links

Drop-In Advising

ISV for New Students & Scholars

U.S. Address Update

Trojan International

Connect With Us

About OIS

News

Contact

Subscribe to Our Newsletter

Privacy Notice

Notice of Non-Discrimination

Copyright © 2

Need help?



Hi there! I'm Tommy, and I am here to answer your questions. What can I help with?